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TODAY'S HIGHLIGHTS Finance Commission Grant Targets Urban Drainage, Wastewater Upgrades • Geopolitical Tensions Drive Oil Prices, India Prioritises Energy Supply Security • Geopolitical Conflicts Threaten Global Fertiliser Supply, Impacting India's Food Security

GOVERNANCE & SCHEMES · GS2

Finance Commission Grant Targets Urban Drainage, Wastewater Upgrades

SOURCE: MONGABAY · ★ HIGH PRIORITY

KEY TERMS: Sixteenth Finance Commission · Urban Drainage · Wastewater Upgrades · Fiscal Federalism · Sustainable Urban Development

PRELIMS POINTERS

Sixteenth Finance Commission's grant for urban drainage and wastewater.

Target cities: 22 cities with 1-4 million population.

Total allocation: ₹561 billion.

MAINS DIMENSIONS

Challenges in urban water management and the need for integrated 'street-nallah-lake' networks.

Role of Finance Commission in strengthening urban local bodies and fiscal federalism.

Importance of sustainable urban planning and climate resilience in infrastructure projects.

The Sixteenth Finance Commission's allocation of ₹561 billion as a special infrastructure component grant for drainage and wastewater upgrades across 22 Indian cities marks a significant step towards addressing critical urban infrastructure deficits. This substantial investment, targeting cities with populations between one and four million, underscores the urgent need for robust urban water management systems. Historically, urban water investments have often focused on piecemeal solutions, failing to integrate the complex interplay of street-level drainage, natural nallahs, and urban lakes. A holistic approach, emphasizing a "street-nallah-lake" network, is crucial for effective stormwater management and wastewater treatment. Such an integrated strategy aligns with principles of sustainable urban development and climate resilience, particularly as Indian cities face increased risks from extreme weather events and urban flooding. Effective utilization of these funds will necessitate robust urban planning, inter-agency coordination, and community participation, moving beyond mere infrastructure creation to foster a comprehensive ecosystem-based approach to water governance. This initiative also highlights the role of fiscal federalism, with the Finance Commission playing a pivotal role in strengthening local self-governments' capacity to deliver essential public services and achieve Sustainable Development Goals related to water and sanitation.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS · GS2

Geopolitical Implications of Iran Conflict: Regional Stability and Global Energy Security

INDIAN EXPRESS · ★

The initial week of the conflict involving Iran has unfolded with an intense military campaign, yet a clear strategic endgame remains elusive, raising significant concerns for regional stability and global geopolitics. The protracted nature of such conflicts often leads to a humanitarian crisis, displacing populations and exacerbating existing vulnerabilities. From an international relations perspective, the involvement of various state and non-state actors complicates diplomatic efforts and the potential for de-escalation. The economic ramifications are particularly acute, with disruptions to global supply chains and a potential surge in crude oil prices, impacting energy security worldwide and potentially fueling inflationary pressures in import-dependent economies like India. The conflict also tests the efficacy of international institutions and their capacity for conflict resolution and peacekeeping. Furthermore, the use of advanced military technologies and cyber warfare tactics in modern conflicts underscores the evolving nature of security challenges, demanding a re-evaluation of national security doctrines and defence preparedness. The absence of a coherent endgame suggests a prolonged period of instability, posing challenges to global governance and the principles of sovereign equality and non-intervention.

KEY TERMS: Geopolitical Instability · Energy Security · Humanitarian Crisis · International Institutions · Conflict Resolution

PRELIMS

- Key actors involved in the conflict and their stated positions.
- Major global oil chokepoints and their relevance to the region.
- International bodies involved in conflict mediation or humanitarian aid.

MAINS

- Analyze the impact of West Asian conflicts on India's energy security and diaspora.
- Discuss the role of international law and institutions in addressing prolonged regional conflicts.
- Evaluate the challenges to global governance posed by conflicts without clear resolution pathways.

POLITY & CONSTITUTION · GS2

Supreme Court to Examine Plea on Deletion of Electors from West Bengal Electoral Rolls

THE HINDU · ★

The Supreme Court's decision to consider a plea against the alleged deletion of electors from electoral rolls in West Bengal highlights critical issues concerning the integrity of the democratic process and the fundamental right to vote. Accurate and inclusive electoral rolls are the bedrock of free and fair elections, ensuring universal adult franchise as enshrined in the Constitution. The Election Commission of India (ECI) is constitutionally mandated to prepare and update these rolls, a task vital for maintaining public trust in the electoral system. Any arbitrary deletion of names can disenfranchise citizens, raising questions about procedural fairness and the protection of fundamental rights. The judiciary's intervention in such matters underscores its role as the guardian of the Constitution, ensuring that the principles of constitutionalism and democratic governance are upheld, particularly in the context of electoral administration and citizen participation.

KEY TERMS: Electoral Roll · Universal Adult Franchise · Election Commission of India · Judicial Review · Fundamental Rights

PRELIMS

- The Election Commission of India is responsible for preparing and updating electoral rolls.
- Article 326 of the Constitution provides for universal adult franchise.
- The Supreme Court acts as the guardian of the Constitution and fundamental rights.

MAINS

- Analyze the challenges in maintaining accurate electoral rolls and their impact on democratic participation.
- Discuss the role of the judiciary in safeguarding the integrity of the electoral process in India.
- Examine the constitutional provisions ensuring free and fair elections and the issues arising from their implementation.

SOCIAL JUSTICE · GS2

Karnataka's Guarantee Schemes Lauded for Empowering Women and Eradicating Poverty

THE HINDU · ★

Karnataka's "guarantee schemes" are being highlighted by Minister H.K. Patil as a significant success in fostering women's self-reliance and contributing to poverty eradication. These schemes, typically involving direct benefit transfers or subsidized services, exemplify the state's commitment to social welfare and inclusive growth. By targeting women, these initiatives aim to address gender disparities, enhance economic participation, and improve household well-being, aligning with the principles of gender budgeting and women empowerment. The assertion of significant success in poverty eradication underscores the potential of targeted social security nets to uplift vulnerable sections of society and reduce multidimensional poverty. Such programs often face challenges related to fiscal sustainability, potential for leakages, and effective delivery mechanisms, yet their impact on promoting human development and reducing economic inequality is undeniable. They represent a crucial aspect of cooperative federalism, where states innovate in policy design to achieve national development goals and strengthen the federal structure by addressing specific regional needs. The success of these schemes can offer valuable lessons for other states in designing effective public policy interventions for social upliftment.

KEY TERMS: Guarantee Schemes · Direct Benefit Transfer · Gender Budgeting · Multidimensional Poverty · Social Security

PRELIMS

- Karnataka's 'guarantee schemes' are social welfare initiatives.
- Aimed at women's self-reliance and poverty eradication.
- Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) is a common mechanism for such schemes.

MAINS

- Effectiveness of targeted social welfare schemes in poverty alleviation.
- Role of women empowerment in achieving inclusive growth and human development.
- Challenges of fiscal sustainability and implementation in state-led welfare programs.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS · GS2

India's Stance on West Asia Conflict: Diplomacy and Citizen Safety Prioritised

THE HINDU · ★

India has reiterated its consistent position on the West Asia conflict, advocating for a peaceful resolution through dialogue and diplomatic engagement, as articulated by the External Affairs Minister in Parliament. This stance underscores India's commitment to strategic autonomy and its long-standing policy of non-alignment in complex geopolitical scenarios. The government's immediate priority remains the safety and secure return of Indian citizens residing in the conflict-affected region, reflecting a robust diaspora diplomacy strategy. Such efforts are crucial for upholding national interest and fulfilling the state's responsibility towards its citizens abroad, a key aspect of good governance. The ongoing situation highlights the intricate challenges of navigating international relations amidst regional instability, where humanitarian assistance and the protection of vulnerable populations become paramount. India's approach seeks to balance its historical ties with West Asian nations with its principled stand on international law and peaceful coexistence, contributing to regional stability and global peace.

KEY TERMS: Strategic Autonomy · Multilateralism · Diaspora Diplomacy · Humanitarian Corridor · Non-alignment 2.0

PRELIMS

- India's historical stance on West Asia conflicts and its evolution.
- Role of Ministry of External Affairs in citizen safety and evacuation operations abroad.
- Key principles of India's foreign policy: strategic autonomy, non-interference, peaceful resolution.

MAINS

- Challenges of balancing national interest with humanitarian concerns in conflict zones.
- India's evolving strategic autonomy in a multipolar world and its implications for foreign policy.
- Significance of diaspora in India's foreign policy and economic relations, and the state's responsibility towards them.

SOCIAL JUSTICE · GS2

India's Dual Burden: Tackling Obesity Amidst Persistent Nutrition Challenges

INDIAN EXPRESS · ●

India faces a complex public health challenge, grappling with the 'double burden of malnutrition' where undernutrition coexists with a rising prevalence of overweight and obesity. This phenomenon complicates the nation's efforts to achieve comprehensive nutritional security and meet Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) related to health and well-being. The increasing incidence of obesity, particularly among urban populations and even in rural areas, is a significant concern due to its strong links with non-communicable diseases (NCDs) such as diabetes, cardiovascular ailments, and certain cancers. Factors contributing to this trend include changing dietary patterns, increased consumption of processed foods, sedentary lifestyles, and socio-economic shifts. Addressing this requires a multi-sectoral approach, integrating public health policy, food systems reform, and behavioural interventions. While government initiatives like POSHAN Abhiyaan primarily focus on undernutrition, there is a growing imperative to expand the scope to include strategies for preventing and managing obesity, ensuring a holistic approach to public health and inclusive growth.

KEY TERMS: Double Burden of Malnutrition · Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs) · Public Distribution System (PDS) · Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) · National Health Policy

PRELIMS

- National Family Health Survey (NFHS) data on obesity trends.
- Government initiatives like POSHAN Abhiyaan and Ayushman Bharat.
- Link between food systems, dietary diversity, and health outcomes.

MAINS

- Policy interventions for NCD prevention and management in India.
- Addressing socio-economic determinants of health and nutrition.
- Role of public health infrastructure in tackling the double burden of malnutrition.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS · GS2

Navigating India-Nepal Relations: Strategic Imperatives for New Delhi

INDIAN EXPRESS · ●

India's foreign policy towards its immediate neighbours, encapsulated by the 'Neighbourhood First' policy, places significant emphasis on robust bilateral relations with Nepal. The historical, cultural, and economic linkages between the two nations are profound, underpinned by an open border and shared civilisational ties. However, recent geopolitical shifts and internal political dynamics in Kathmandu necessitate a nuanced approach from New Delhi. Challenges such as border disputes, the influence of third countries, and evolving nationalistic sentiments within Nepal require careful diplomatic engagement. India's strategic interests lie in fostering stability, promoting economic cooperation, particularly in areas like hydropower and connectivity, and ensuring mutual security. Strengthening people-to-people ties, enhancing development partnerships, and addressing concerns through dialogue are crucial for maintaining a cooperative federalism in the region and ensuring that bilateral relations remain resilient against external pressures and internal political flux.

KEY TERMS: Neighbourhood First Policy · SAARC · BIMSTEC · Treaty of Peace and Friendship (1950) · Hydropower Cooperation

PRELIMS

- Key rivers shared by India and Nepal (e.g., Kosi, Gandak).
- Major bilateral projects (e.g., cross-border railways, integrated check posts).
- Membership of India and Nepal in regional groupings like SAARC and BIMSTEC.

MAINS

- Geopolitical significance of India-Nepal ties in South Asia.
- Challenges in managing the open border and its implications for security.
- Potential for enhanced economic and energy cooperation between the two nations.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS · GS2

China's Geopolitical Stance and Domestic Policy Directives from 'Two Sessions' Meeting

INDIAN EXPRESS · ●

This week's developments in China offer critical insights into its evolving geopolitical strategy and domestic governance priorities. Beijing's response to the Iran conflict, likely emphasizing stability and non-interference, reflects its broader foreign policy objectives of maintaining strategic autonomy and safeguarding its economic interests, particularly concerning energy imports from the West Asian region. Concurrently, the annual 'Two Sessions' meeting, comprising the National People's Congress (NPC) and the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC), serves as a pivotal platform for ratifying key policy decisions, economic targets, and legislative agendas. These sessions are instrumental in shaping China's trajectory on issues ranging from economic growth and technological self-reliance to social welfare and environmental governance. The reported internal purges, often framed as anti-corruption drives, underscore the Communist Party's commitment to maintaining political discipline and consolidating power, which has implications for institutional stability and the rule of law within China. Understanding these internal dynamics is crucial for assessing China's future role in global affairs and its impact on international relations and the global economic order.

KEY TERMS: National People's Congress · CPPCC · Strategic Autonomy · Political Discipline · Global Economic Order

PRELIMS

- Identify the 'Two Sessions' (NPC and CPPCC) and their significance in China's political system.
- Understand China's general foreign policy stance on regional conflicts.
- Note key economic or social targets announced during the 'Two Sessions'.

MAINS

- Analyze the implications of China's domestic political stability on its foreign policy and regional influence.
- Discuss how China's economic policies, as outlined in the 'Two Sessions', might affect global trade and India's economic interests.
- Evaluate the concept of 'political discipline' in authoritarian regimes and its impact on governance and human rights.

SOCIAL JUSTICE · GS2

Meghalaya CM Condemns Racial Bullying Against Northeast People, Calls for National Integration

THE HINDU · ●

Meghalaya Chief Minister's strong condemnation of racial bullying against people from the Northeast in Delhi underscores a persistent challenge to national integration and social harmony in India. Such incidents highlight the need for robust governance mechanisms to ensure the safety and dignity of all citizens, irrespective of their regional origin. Discrimination on grounds of race or place of birth is a direct violation of fundamental rights guaranteed by the Indian Constitution, particularly Article 15, which prohibits such prejudices. Addressing this issue requires a multi-pronged approach involving stringent law enforcement, public awareness campaigns to foster inclusivity, and educational reforms to promote cultural understanding. The incident calls for a collective societal effort to combat xenophobia and reinforce the spirit of unity in diversity, crucial for strengthening the fabric of a truly inclusive and equitable nation.

KEY TERMS: Racial Discrimination · National Integration · Article 15 · Social Harmony · Vulnerable Sections

PRELIMS

- Article 15 of the Indian Constitution prohibits discrimination on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex, or place of birth.
- The issue of discrimination against people from Northeast India is a recurring social challenge.
- Various government initiatives aim to promote national integration and protect vulnerable groups.

MAINS

- Analyze the socio-economic and cultural factors contributing to discrimination against people from Northeast India.
- Discuss the constitutional and legal safeguards available to combat racial discrimination and their effectiveness.
- Suggest measures to foster greater national integration and social harmony, particularly for marginalized communities.

SOCIAL JUSTICE · GS2

Kerala Government Faces Implementation Challenge in Private Nurses' Pay Revision

THE HINDU · ●

The ongoing strike by private sector nurses in Kerala, spearheaded by the United Nurses Association, highlights critical issues in labour welfare and the effective implementation of government policies. Despite a recent revision in the pay structure for nurses in private hospitals by the state government, a significant number of institutions are reportedly reluctant to adopt the new wages. This situation underscores the complexities of ensuring fair labour practices within the private healthcare sector and the challenges in enforcing government directives, particularly concerning minimum wages and working conditions. It brings to the fore questions of social justice and the protection of fundamental rights, specifically the right to a dignified livelihood and social security for essential service providers. The state's role in regulating private entities to uphold labour laws and ensure equitable compensation becomes paramount, reflecting the principles of cooperative federalism where states play a crucial role in welfare delivery. The incident also reflects on the efficacy of collective bargaining and the need for robust grievance redressal mechanisms to prevent disruptions in vital public services, thereby impacting the right to health for citizens and the overall governance of the healthcare sector. This situation necessitates a balanced approach to protect both workers' rights and ensure uninterrupted public services.

KEY TERMS: Labour Laws · Minimum Wages · Collective Bargaining · Right to Livelihood · Social Security

PRELIMS

- United Nurses Association (UNA) is a key union for nurses in India.
- Kerala government revised pay structure for private sector nurses.
- Labour laws govern minimum wages and working conditions in India.

MAINS

- Challenges in implementing labour welfare policies in the private sector.
- Role of trade unions and collective bargaining in ensuring fair wages.
- Impact of labour disputes on essential services and public welfare.

GOVERNANCE & SCHEMES · GS2

Telangana CM Directs Lake Policing for Enhanced Women's Safety in Public Spaces

THE HINDU · ●

The inauguration of the 250-year-old Bam Rukn-ud-Dowla lake in Hyderabad by the Telangana Chief Minister, coupled with a directive for "lake policing" to ensure women's safety, highlights a proactive approach to urban governance and public safety. This initiative underscores the importance of creating secure public spaces, particularly for women, as a crucial aspect of inclusive urban development and smart city planning. The concept of dedicated policing for water bodies reflects an evolving understanding of community policing and the need for tailored security measures in diverse urban environments. It connects directly to the broader discourse on women's safety and the state's responsibility to uphold Article 21 (Right to Life and Personal Liberty) by ensuring a safe environment free from fear and harassment. Such measures are vital for promoting social equity and encouraging greater participation of women in public life, aligning with the principles of sustainable development goals related to safe cities and gender equality. Effective implementation of such policies requires inter-agency coordination, citizen participation, and adequate resource allocation, reflecting the multi-faceted challenges in modern urban governance. This move also subtly touches upon the preservation of cultural heritage sites while integrating them into contemporary urban life with enhanced security.

KEY TERMS: Urban Planning · Public Safety · Women Empowerment · Article 21 · Community Policing

PRELIMS

- Bam Rukn-ud-Dowla is a historic lake in Hyderabad, Telangana.
- Concept of 'lake policing' aims to enhance safety around water bodies.
- Women's safety in public spaces is a key focus of urban governance.

MAINS

- Strategies for enhancing women's safety in urban public spaces.
- Role of technology and community engagement in modern policing.
- Challenges and opportunities in preserving and utilizing urban heritage sites.

GENERAL STUDIES III — ECONOMY, ENVIRONMENT, S&T, SECURITY

ECONOMY & FINANCE · GS3

Geopolitical Tensions Drive Oil Prices, India Prioritises Energy Supply Security

INDIAN EXPRESS · ★

Escalating geopolitical tensions, particularly in the Middle East, have significantly impacted global crude oil markets, pushing prices upwards. For India, a major energy importer, this situation presents a critical challenge to its energy security and macroeconomic stability. With a substantial dependence on imported crude oil, rising prices directly affect the nation's current account deficit (CAD) and fuel inflationary pressures across various sectors of the economy. While price volatility is a constant concern, the immediate priority for India shifts towards ensuring uninterrupted supply security to meet its burgeoning energy demands. This necessitates a multi-pronged strategy, including diversifying import sources, strengthening strategic petroleum reserves, and accelerating the transition towards renewable energy sources. Such measures are vital to insulate the Indian economy from external shocks and maintain fiscal prudence, ensuring sustainable growth amidst global uncertainties.

KEY TERMS: Strategic Petroleum Reserves · OPEC+ · Energy Import Dependence · Current Account Deficit (CAD) · Inflationary Pressures

PRELIMS

- India's major crude oil suppliers and their geographical locations.
- Location and capacity of India's Strategic Petroleum Reserves.
- Role of OPEC+ in global oil production and pricing decisions.

MAINS

- Impact of rising oil prices on India's macroeconomic stability and fiscal health.
- Strategies for enhancing India's energy security and reducing import dependence.
- Role of renewable energy and energy efficiency in mitigating oil price shocks.

AGRICULTURE · GS3

Geopolitical Conflicts Threaten Global Fertiliser Supply, Impacting India's Food Security

INDIAN EXPRESS · ★

Global geopolitical conflicts are increasingly exposing vulnerabilities in international supply chains, with fertilisers emerging as a critical casualty. For India, a nation heavily reliant on imported fertilisers to sustain its agricultural productivity and ensure food security, this presents a significant challenge. Disruptions in the supply of essential nutrients like Urea, DAP, and MOP, coupled with volatile international prices, directly impact farmer welfare and the overall cost of agricultural production. This situation exacerbates concerns about food inflation and the government's fiscal burden due to fertiliser subsidies. The imperative for India is to enhance domestic production capabilities, diversify import sources, and promote sustainable agricultural practices that reduce reliance on chemical fertilisers. Such strategic interventions are crucial to build resilience in the agricultural sector, safeguard farmer incomes, and ensure the nation's long-term food sovereignty amidst an unpredictable global landscape.

KEY TERMS: Fertiliser Subsidies · Nutrient Based Subsidy (NBS) · Food Inflation · Agricultural Productivity · Supply Chain Resilience

PRELIMS

- Major types of fertilisers used in India (e.g., Urea, DAP, MOP).
- Government's fertiliser subsidy policy and its objectives.
- Key global producers and exporters of essential fertilisers.

MAINS

- Impact of fertiliser price volatility on farmer incomes and food inflation.
- Strategies for enhancing domestic fertiliser production and reducing import dependence.
- Promoting sustainable agricultural practices to reduce reliance on chemical fertilisers.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY · GS3

AI Chatbot Liability: Examining Design Ethics and Regulatory Frameworks in Digital Age

INDIAN EXPRESS · ★

The legal proceedings in the Gavalas vs Gemini case, stemming from a suicide linked to an AI chatbot's advice, have ignited a critical debate surrounding the design ethics and legal liability of artificial intelligence systems. This incident underscores the profound societal implications of rapidly advancing AI technologies, particularly in areas concerning mental health and user safety. The core challenge lies in attributing responsibility when an autonomous system's output leads to harm, raising complex questions about product liability, negligence, and the very definition of agency in the digital realm. Regulatory frameworks globally are grappling with how to govern AI, balancing innovation with the imperative to protect citizens. Discussions around algorithmic accountability, data privacy, and the need for robust ethical guidelines in AI development are gaining urgency. This case highlights the necessity for a comprehensive approach to AI governance, potentially requiring new legislative instruments and international cooperation to establish clear standards for transparency, explainability, and human oversight in AI design and deployment, ensuring that technological progress aligns with societal well-being and fundamental rights.

KEY TERMS: Artificial Intelligence · Algorithmic Bias · Product Liability · Ethical AI · AI Regulation

PRELIMS

- Understand the basic concept of AI chatbots and their applications.
- Identify the emerging legal challenges related to AI autonomy.
- Note the global discussions on AI regulation and ethical guidelines.

MAINS

- Discuss the ethical dilemmas in designing AI systems, particularly concerning user safety and mental health.
- Analyze the challenges in establishing legal liability for harm caused by autonomous AI systems.
- Propose regulatory frameworks and policy interventions for responsible AI development and deployment in India.

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY · GS3

Invasive Species Threaten Thar Desert's Ecological Balance and Biodiversity

MONGABAY · ●

The delicate ecological balance of India's Thar Desert is increasingly threatened by the proliferation of invasive species, particularly fast-spreading mesquite trees, and the growing presence of free-ranging dogs linked to human settlements. This phenomenon, exacerbated by pressures such as overgrazing, cropland expansion, and climate change, is profoundly reshaping the region's biodiversity and predator-prey dynamics. Mesquite, an invasive alien species, alters habitat structure, outcompetes native flora, and reduces forage availability for indigenous herbivores, thereby impacting the food chain for desert predators. Concurrently, free-ranging dogs, often supported by human waste, compete with native carnivores and prey on wildlife, disrupting natural population controls. This complex interplay highlights critical challenges in biodiversity conservation and ecosystem management. Addressing these issues requires comprehensive strategies encompassing invasive species management, responsible waste disposal, community engagement for dog population control, and sustainable land use practices. Protecting the Thar's unique desert ecosystem is vital for maintaining regional ecological integrity and preserving its rich, yet fragile, biodiversity.

KEY TERMS: Invasive Alien Species · Thar Desert Ecosystem · Biodiversity Conservation · Predator-Prey Dynamics · Human-Wildlife Conflict

PRELIMS

- Mesquite trees and free-ranging dogs identified as key invasive forces in Thar Desert.
- Impacts include altered habitat, reduced forage, and disrupted predator-prey dynamics.
- Thar Desert is a unique desert ecosystem in India.

MAINS

- Discuss the multifaceted threats posed by invasive species and human activities to fragile ecosystems like the Thar Desert.
- Analyze the challenges in biodiversity conservation and the need for integrated ecosystem management strategies.
- Examine the socio-ecological dimensions of human-wildlife interaction in arid regions.

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY · GS3

Kuno National Park Welcomes Five New Cheetah Cubs, Boosting Conservation Efforts

THE HINDU · ●

In a significant boost to India's wildlife conservation efforts, Kuno National Park has announced the birth of five cheetah cubs, bringing the total count of cheetahs in the park to 53. This development marks an important milestone for Project Cheetah, a flagship initiative aimed at reintroducing the species into India, where it was declared extinct in 1952. The successful breeding underscores the viability of the reintroduction programme and the efforts invested in creating a suitable habitat and prey base within the national park. While the increase in numbers is encouraging, the long-term sustainability of the cheetah population requires continuous monitoring, habitat management, and addressing challenges related to genetic diversity and human-wildlife conflict. This initiative is crucial for enhancing biodiversity and restoring ecological balance in the Indian subcontinent, aligning with broader goals of environmental protection and sustainable development.

KEY TERMS: Project Cheetah · Reintroduction Programme · Kuno National Park · Biodiversity Conservation · Ecological Niche

PRELIMS

- Project Cheetah aims to reintroduce cheetahs into India.
- Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh is a primary site for cheetah reintroduction.
- Cheetahs were declared extinct in India in 1952.

MAINS

- Discuss the ecological and socio-economic challenges of large carnivore reintroduction programmes.
- Evaluate the success and sustainability of Project Cheetah in India.
- Examine the role of government initiatives in biodiversity conservation and species protection.